PRODUCT MANAGEMENT LAUNCHPAD · CAPSTONE

Porter: Building First-Time Goods Transport Confidence

A product strategy to take successful first-trip conversion from 41% to 58% within six months.

Prepared for: **Porter Leadership Team**

Focus: **Consumer-facing, first-time individual customers**

Author: Airtribe capstone submission

Porter today: scale built on business logistics

Founded 2014 · India's largest intra-city logistics marketplace · ~$1.2B valuation (2025 funding round)

3.6 cr+	30 lakh+	20 lakh+	23	3 lakh+	2
customers served	monthly customers	MSME customers / mo	Indian cities	active driver-partners	countries

THE GAP

20 lakh+ monthly customers are MSMEs who've built booking intuition over dozens of trips. The individual, first-time mover hasn't — and today's experience treats them the same way.

Frequent business users move goods often enough to build working intuition about how the service behaves. First-time individual customers are making these judgments for the first time — usually under time pressure, often on a day that matters to them.

Making vehicles available isn't the same as making the trip feel safe to book

A first-time Porter user knows they need to move a sofa, a fridge, or a stack of boxes across the city. What they haven't built yet is the judgment to translate that need into a booking — the exact judgment frequent business users pick up after dozens of trips. A goods trip also succeeds or fails in the physical world, after the booking is placed, which makes it different from a purely digital conversion problem.

PROBLEM STATEMENT

Among first-time individual users who enter pickup/drop and reach the vehicle-selection screen, only 41% complete a successful first trip within 7 days — causing abandonment, rebooking, or a return to offline options.

TARGET · 6 MONTHS

41% → **58%** successful first-trip conversion

Research approach

1 Segments

- First-time users who reached vehicle-selection
- Offline-only movers — tempo, packers & movers, friend's car
- Repeat Porter users, as a confidence baseline

2 Methods

- Structured survey — 20 completed responses (final evidence base)
- App-review / friction-phrase mining
- 3 recorded 1:1 interviews as a qualitative layer (see note below)

3 Timeline

- Week 1: survey fielding + review mining
- Week 1–2: interviews across segments
- Week 2: synthesis into personas & barriers

EVIDENCE NOTE

Evidence base: 20 structured-survey responses plus 3 recorded 1:1 interviews across first-time, offline-only and repeat users. Full 20-row tracker with every quote: companion appendix, Porter_User_Interaction_Tracker.xlsx.

USER-INTERACTION TRACKER — SAMPLE (5 of 20; full tracker in appendix)

User	Type	Channel	Key insight / quote
U01	Offline-only mover	Survey	Had no clear way to judge vehicle size — leaned on a rough guess
U05	Repeat Porter user	Survey	"Driver reliability and response after booking… no cancellation once confirmed"
U07	Offline-only mover	Survey	Lowest confidence (1/5) — vehicle came too small, needed a second trip
U11	First-time Porter user	Survey	Hit the #1 feared outcome (extra charges) on their very first trip
U16	Offline-only mover	Survey	Wants live tracking so they know where their goods physically are

Seven research questions, with testable hypotheses

Working hypotheses to validate against the completed 20-response sample and follow-on interviews.

#	Research question	Working hypothesis
RQ1	Can first-time users translate their goods into the right vehicle?	H1: Vehicle fit/selection is a major first-trip confidence barrier.
RQ2	Do users understand the total cost before committing?	H2: Price uncertainty materially reduces booking confidence.
RQ3	Do users seek help from another person before booking?	H3: Many first-timers use a human “second opinion.”
RQ4	Which trust signals matter most before booking?	H4: Driver identity, confirmation and reliability reduce anxiety.
RQ5	What happens when the selected vehicle is wrong?	H5: Fit errors create failed trips, extra trips or dissatisfaction.
RQ6	What information would make a first-time user feel ready?	H6: Goods examples, vehicle visuals and clear fare details increase confidence.
RQ7	What single change would users prioritize?	H7: Highest-value improvements cluster around fit, price and reliability.

Top anticipated barriers to a completed first trip

TOP 4 ANTICIPATED BARRIERS (BEFORE RESEARCH SYNTHESIS)

- **Can't judge if the goods will fit the vehicle** — 45% of survey respondents cited vehicle fit as a top concern; two interviewees misjudged size on their first booking
- **Price feels uncertain until it's too late** — 55% feared the final price and 50% feared extra add-on charges — the top two cited concerns (survey, n=20)
- **No in-app equivalent to a trusted human opinion** — 45% asked a friend or family member before booking; one interview described an add-on option that was simply misunderstood without help
- **The trip can still fail after booking is confirmed** — 30% cited driver reliability; a goods trip succeeds or fails physically, after the app's job is already done

WHERE THESE BARRIERS SHOW UP

Before booking

Fit and price uncertainty drive hesitation and the "ask a friend" detour before a booking even starts

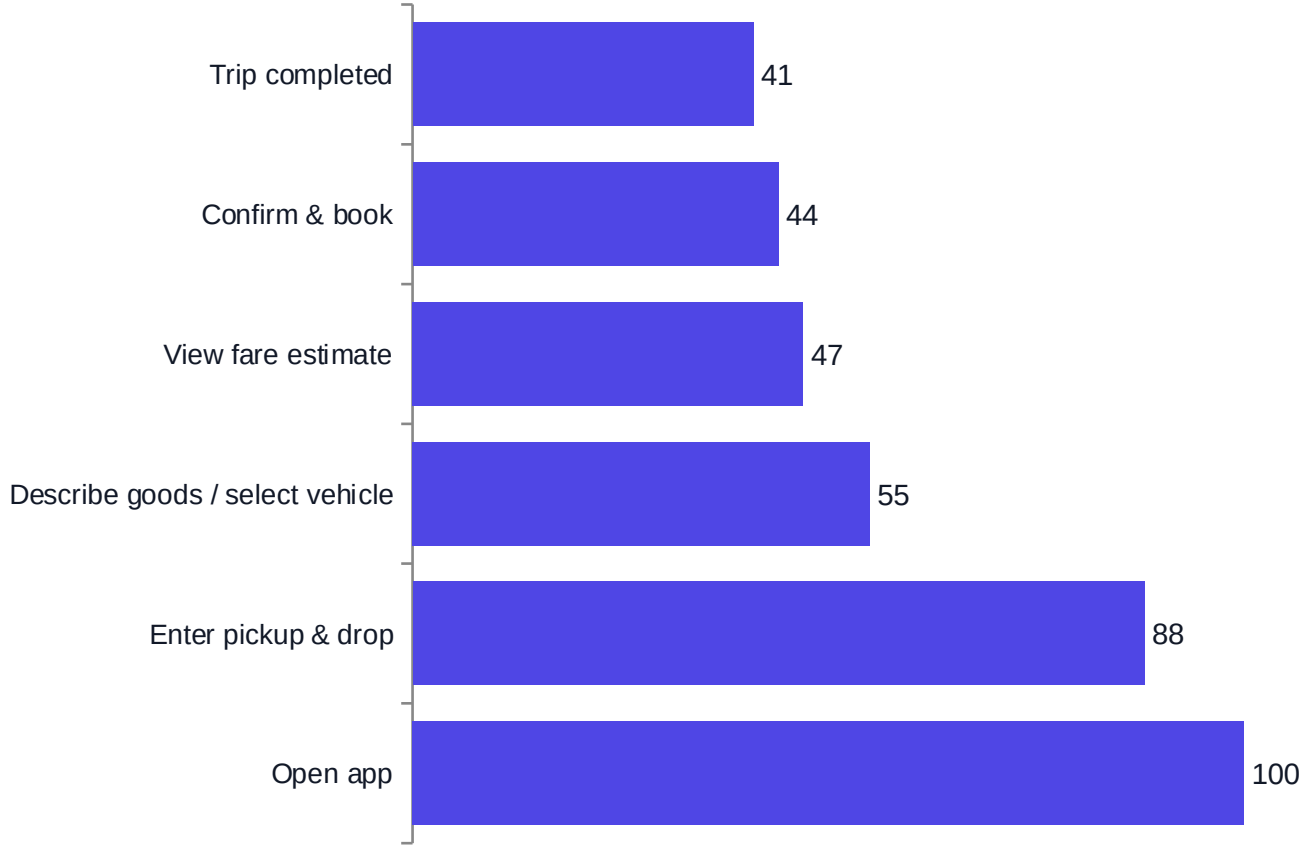
At vehicle-selection

The steepest funnel drop-off happens exactly here — see the deep-dive on the next slide

After booking

Driver trust and physical fulfillment risk can still fail a trip the app already counted as booked

The steepest drop-off is where confidence runs out



STEEPEST DROP

88% → 55%

Describe goods → select vehicle. A 33-point loss — the single largest cliff in the funnel.

WHY IT MATTERS

This is exactly where the case study's success metric is anchored: translating “my sofa & fridge” into a vehicle choice is the primary barrier standing between 41% and the 58% target.

Data source: reconstructed from the 20-response survey and interview self-reports (participants' recalled drop-off points), not pulled from Porter's live product analytics. Treat as a directional estimate.

What your own users told you

Top concerns cited across 20 survey respondents

55%	11/20	**Price is the #1 concern** — Total/final price was the single most-cited concern.
50%	10/20	**Extra charges** — Fear of add-on charges appearing after booking.
45%	9/20	**Vehicle choice & fit** — Choosing the right vehicle and/or whether goods would fit.
45%	9/20	**A trusted second opinion** — Asked someone else for help deciding how to transport goods.
30%	6/20	**Driver reliability** — Concerned about driver reliability or availability.

ALTERNATIVES USED

Porter (app-based)	13/20
Local tempo / mini-truck	3/20
Packers & Movers	2/20
Other / personal route	2/20

Porter already wins the individual-mover use case on convenience — the opportunity is finishing the job it starts, not out-competing offline options.

How first-time movers solve this today

Where Porter already wins, and where offline options still beat it — mapped against the five things users said they need most.

Criteria	Porter (today)	Local tempo / mini-truck	Packers & Movers	Other apps	Porter's opportunity
Vehicle-fit guidance	None — self-select	Driver's judgement	Site survey	Mostly none	**Close this — steepest funnel drop-off (Slide 6)**
Price shown before booking	Estimate, extras later	Negotiated on-spot	Quoted after survey	Varies by app	**All-in fare = matches P&M trust, keeps on-demand speed**
Driver/mover trust signal	Verified profile, rating	Personal/ referral trust	Company reputation	Varies by app	**Already a relative strength — make it more visible**
Booking speed	Minutes	Minutes to hours	Days (scheduled)	Minutes	**Structural advantage — protect it, don't slow it down**
Accountability if damaged	Limited claims process	Informal, low recourse	Contractual, insured	Varies by app	**Clarify policy upfront — cheap fix for real anxiety**
Human 'second opinion'	None — self-serve	Driver often advises	Surveyor advises	None	**Digital recommender replaces the informal advisor**

THE TAKEAWAY Porter already beats offline options on speed and largely on trust infrastructure, but loses on vehicle-fit guidance and price transparency — exactly where Packers & Movers and word-of-mouth still win. Closing those two gaps without giving up on-demand speed is the whole strategy.

Two first-time-mover personas

TA

The Anxious First-Mover

Confidence 1–2/5 · never or rarely booked goods transport online

BIGGEST FEAR

Goods won't fit, or the price will change after booking.

COPING BEHAVIOR

Asks a friend or family member for a second opinion before booking.

WHAT WOULD MOVE THEM

A booking flow that speaks plain language, confirms fit up front, and locks the price before they confirm.

TC

The Control-Seeking Switcher

Confidence 4–5/5 · 2–3+ prior Porter trips, one bad experience

BIGGEST FEAR

A repeat of a past driver-reliability or damage problem.

COPING BEHAVIOR

Still books, but double-checks driver details and braces for something to go wrong.

WHAT WOULD MOVE THEM

Visible driver confirmation and an itemized, no-surprise fare — not more goods-fit guidance, which they no longer need.

12 ideas, prioritized by RICE

RICE = (Reach × Impact × Confidence) ÷ Effort — relative prioritization assumptions, to validate with product/engineering estimates before build.

Idea	R	I	C	E	RICE
Goods-based vehicle recommender	9	3	0.80	3	**7.65**
Transparent, all-in fare	9	3	0.85	3.5	**6.56**
Itemized charge breakdown	8	2	0.80	2	**6.40**
Visual fit guide	7	1.5	0.70	2	**3.68**
Peer-proof messaging	7	1	0.70	1.5	**3.27**
Driver + helper preview	6	1.5	0.70	2	**3.15**
30-sec guided quiz	6	1.5	0.60	2.5	**2.16**
Save & resume w/ recommendation	5	1	0.70	2	**1.75**
Live capacity meter	4	1	0.50	2	**1.00**
In-app chat fallback	3	1	0.60	2	**0.90**
Declared-value protection	4	1	0.50	3	**0.67**
Photo-upload estimator	5	1	0.40	4	**0.50**

The top 2 solutions

Chosen because together they answer both halves of the problem: will it fit, and is this the real price.

01 Goods-based vehicle recommender

A guided checklist/quiz that maps real items — sofa, fridge, boxes — directly to a vehicle. No vehicle jargon required, and always skippable.

Highest RICE score in the set (7.65)

02 Transparent, all-in fare

One itemized number shown before the user commits to a vehicle — labor, extra-person and waiting charges included, not added later.

2nd-highest RICE score (6.56); directly closes the price-trust gap

Trade-off analysis

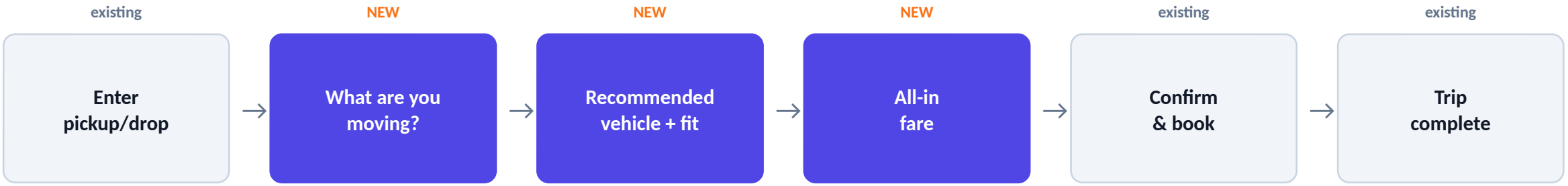
What each solution optimizes for, and what it consciously sacrifices — especially between added guidance and on-demand speed.

	Optimizes for	Sacrifices / Mitigation
Goods-based recommender	vehicle-fit confidence for first-timers	**Sacrifices:** a few extra seconds vs. an instant book **Mitigation:** off by default once a user has trip history; always skippable
Transparent, all-in fare	trust — no post-booking price surprises	**Sacrifices:** the attractive low “teaser” price shown upfront today **Mitigation:** A/B test the framing; watch top-of-funnel entry rate separately

THE SHARED TRADE-OFF

Both solutions add a step before booking. For confident, repeat users this is dead weight — so the guided path defaults ON only for users with no completed-trip history, and is always skippable for everyone else. Speed is preserved for the segment that already has it; guidance is spent only where it's needed.

The new flow, inside the existing app



DESIGN RATIONALE

- Guided path defaults ON only for users with no completed-trip history — always skippable.
- Fit confidence uses plain icons and language, not AR or camera scanning — faster to ship, matches what users actually asked for.
- All-in fare is shown before vehicle confirmation, not after — removing price-surprise at the exact moment it causes hesitation.

WORKING PROTOTYPE

A clickable HTML prototype of the 3 new screens — goods input, vehicle recommendation, all-in fare — plus the existing confirm-and-book screen. Live: admirable-semifreddo-8e3d66.netlify.app

Screens: 1) Goods input ("2-seater sofa + fridge + 4 boxes", plain language, no vehicle jargon) 2) Recommendation ("Recommended: Mini Truck" + fit rationale + confidence + image) 3) All-in fare ("₹X total — no surprise add-ons", itemized).

PRD — MVP scope

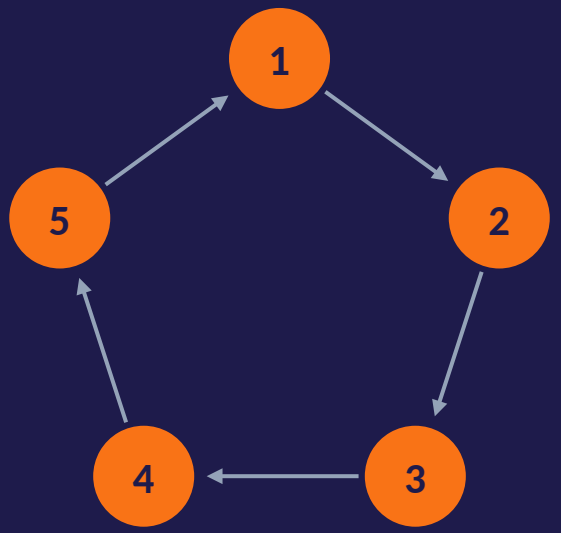
USER	First-time individual goods mover
PROBLEM	Cannot confidently map goods → vehicle → final cost
MVP	Guided goods input + vehicle recommendation + all-in fare
IN SCOPE	Item categories, fit rationale, vehicle visuals, itemized total
OUT OF SCOPE	Pricing-engine redesign, fleet expansion, driver incentive redesign
SUCCESS METRIC	Move first-trip completion from 41% toward 58% without worsening guardrails

Launch focused, then let it loop

LAUNCH PLAN

- One metro first — the city with the highest individual (non-MSME) booking share.
- Rolled out as a feature flag on the existing app, not new acquisition spend.
- Goal in weeks 1–3: validate the funnel lift on existing traffic before scaling.

GROWTH LOOP



1 Confident first trip completed
2 User rates it — “fit as expected, arrived safely”
3 App saves this move's items + vehicle profile
4 Next booking pre-fills — faster than trip one
5 Repeat usage + relevant referral moment

What a 17-point lift is worth

A directional model. The worked numbers below use an illustrative placeholder volume — swap in Porter's actual first-time booking volume to get real figures.

Incremental completed trips / month	*= (58% − 41%) × monthly first-time bookings reaching vehicle-selection*
Incremental revenue / month	*= incremental completed trips × average individual-segment fare*
Incremental LTV impact	*= incremental completed trips × month-2 repeat-booking uplift for smooth first trips*

ILLUSTRATIVE WORKED EXAMPLE (placeholder volume: 50,000 first-timers/mo reach vehicle-selection)

+8,500

incremental completed trips / month
(17% × 50,000)

~₹38L

incremental revenue / month
(at an illustrative ₹450 avg. fare)

+1,700

incremental repeat bookings, month 2
(at an illustrative 20% uplift)

A cohort-based rollout

Launch to existing traffic first; scale only when first-trip conversion improves without guardrail regressions.

Cohort 1

10%

Weeks 1–2

Validate usability + recommendation accuracy

Cohort 2

25%

Weeks 3–4

Require no material guardrail regression

Cohort 3

50%

Weeks 5–6

Confirm lift across user segments

Cohort 4

100%

Week 7+

Scale if success criteria hold

How we'll know it's working

NORTH STAR

Successful First-Trip Completion Rate — target 58% within 7 days, up from 41%

Supporting

- Vehicle-selection completion rate
- Fare-estimate → confirm conversion
- Recommender acceptance rate
- Time-to-book for first-timers

Guardrail

- Post-booking cancellation rate
- Rebooking-after-cancel rate
- Fare-dispute rate
- Damage-claim rate

Event tracking

- goods_input_started
- goods_submitted
- vehicle_recommendation_shown
- vehicle_recommendation_accepted
- all_in_fare_viewed
- booking_confirmed
- trip_completed

Risks, trade-offs & constraints for v1

RISKS & MITIGATIONS

! **Wrong-size recommendation — surfaces only during physical fulfillment** — Bias recommendations conservative; easy in-trip upsize path

! **Guided steps slow down confident, repeat users** — Skippable by design; defaults off for users with booking history

! **All-in fare looks higher than today's teaser price** — A/B test “no surprises” framing; watch top-of-funnel entry separately

! **Recommender needs volume to be accurate — cold start** — Ship rule-based first; invest in ML once labeled data exists

CHOSEN NOT TO SOLVE (THIS PHASE)

- Guidance over raw speed — accepting a few extra seconds for first-timers to prevent failed trips
- Presentation, not pricing engine — hidden charges are a real lever, but the engine itself is out of scope
- Not fixing driver reliability directly — a real barrier, flagged as the strongest phase-2 candidate

CONSTRAINTS & ASSUMPTIONS

PRICING	All-in fare must be assembled from today's pricing engine — no new pricing logic, only earlier and clearer surfacing of existing charges.
OPERATIONAL	No change to driver-partner supply, dispatch, or fleet mix. The recommender must work within today's available vehicle categories only.
DATA / COLD START	No historical goods-to-vehicle mapping exists yet. V1 recommender must ship rule-based — an ML model needs labeled outcomes it doesn't have.
CAPACITY	Engineering scope limited to app-layer changes (3 new screens + 1 existing flow edit) — no backend rebuild, in line with the case study's out-of-scope list.
SAMPLE SIZE	Research evidence rests on 23 documented interactions (20 survey + 3 interviews), not a large-scale study — directional, not statistically definitive.
TIMELINE	6-month target assumes the guided flow ships to Cohort 1 within weeks 1–2 — any delay to that ship date pushes the full 41%→58% timeline out equally.

Working AI artifact: “What Vehicle Do I Need?”

A rule-based recommender demo, provided as a companion interactive HTML artifact: plain-language goods input → vehicle recommendation with confidence + fit rationale → itemized all-in fare — the exact core flow from Slide 14, built and clickable. Live: admirable-semifreddo-8e3d66.netlify.app. Production would need a secure backend and real fare/catalog data.

41% → 58%

by giving first-time users the two answers they've been missing: will it fit, and is this the real price.

BIGGEST RISK TO WATCH

Recommendation accuracy once it meets real-world loading conditions — the failure mode that only shows up after the app closes.